

Dynamic Mics on Drum Overheads — Live

Rationale, mic selection from your kit, technique notes

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WHY RUN DYNAMICS OVERHEAD

REASONS TO DO IT

- Less sensitive → better feedback resistance on loud stages
- High SPL headroom — no capsule overload
- Natural HF rolloff tames harsh/bright cymbals
- Picks up less stage wash, monitor bleed, room reflections
- Outdoor/festival durability — condensers are finicky in open air
- No phantom (moving-coil) — one less dependency

TRADE-OFFS

- Less air above ~12 kHz — cymbal sheen is reduced
- More preamp gain needed
- More coloration than a neutral SDC
- Tight polar patterns require precise placement
- Not the call for natural room/classical overhead work
- Ribbons: NO phantom power — phantom kills them

YOUR MICS — MOVING-COIL DYNAMICS

Mic	Pattern / Kit	Overhead use notes	Rating
SM57	Cardioid — standalone	Classic stereo overhead pair. Presence peak (~5–10 kHz) partially recovers lost HF. Works especially well for rock/country where you want controlled, punchy cymbals without air. Spaced pair or XY. Nearly indestructible outdoors.	First Call
Audix i5	Hypercardioid — DP8	Tight pattern = better rejection than the SM57. Good SPL handling and a punchy response. Works as a close overhead or individual cymbal mic — the hypercardioid means careful aim matters. Underused in this role.	Strong Option
MD421 II	Cardioid — standalone	Primary role is toms, but	Secondary

viable on
overheads for
heavy/rock
contexts. Use
the bass
rolloff switch
(position 2–3)
to cut the low-
end buildup.
Awkward to
position up
top due to size
and clip
design.
Reserve when
SM57s are
tied up.

sE V7 X	Supercardioid — V Pack	Instrument dynamic with extended HF for a dynamic — a little more open on top than an SM57. Reasonable overhead option if the V Pack is deployed and you have a free pair. Supercardioid: watch the rear lobe in close cymbal work.	Workable
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YOUR MICS — RIBBON DYNAMICS

⚠ **Ribbon warning — NO phantom power, ever. Verify before patching.**

Phantom voltage will destroy the ribbon element instantly. Double-check your desk and any splitter feeds before connecting R-121, R-10, or R88.

Mic	Pattern / Kit	Overhead use notes	Rating
AEA R88	Fig-8 stereo — standalone	Your go-to room/ overhead ribbon, already in the workflow (listed for this). Blumlein stereo in one body — excellent natural ambience, smooth top end,	Ribbon — First Call

no
harshness.
Ideal for a
jazz/
acoustic
kit where
you want
air without
condenser
brightness.
Gain-
hungry:
needs
clean
preamp
headroom.

Royer R-10

Fig-8 — standalone

More
compact
and
resilient
than the
R88. Can
run as a
spaced
pair for
overhead.
Less
extended
top end
than the
R88 but
warmer
low-mids.
Primary
role is
guitar cab,
but room/
overhead
use is
solid —
especially
when you
want that
soft
cymbal
character
without
edginess.

Ribbon — Secondary

Royer R-121

Fig-8 — standalone

Primarily
the guitar
cab blend
mic (CH15
at Memo).
Technically
viable as
an
overhead
but this is
stepping
outside its
primary
role and
it'll be
missed on

Leave on Cab

the guitar cab. Only reach here if guitar isn't in the rig.

TECHNIQUE

Spaced Pair (A/B)	Two mics at the 1/3 / 2/3 points across the kit, ~3–5 ft above cymbals. Standard approach. Wide image. Phase-check snare and toms against close mics — time-align everything. SM57 pair is the obvious choice here.
XY / Coincident	Two mics crossed at ~90°, capsules coincident above the kit. Mono-compatible, minimal phase issues, narrower image. SM57s or i5s work well — the i5's tight hypercardioid makes XY very rejection-friendly.
Close Cymbal Miking	One mic per cymbal group (crash/hi-hat, ride). Position 6–12 in. above, angled at the edge, away from the bell. i5 or SM57. Better for IEM-heavy rigs. Avoids the whole-kit bleed problem entirely.
Blumlein (R88)	R88 as a single overhead above the kit. Naturally produces a wide stereo image in mono-compatible mid-side-like fashion. Smooth top end — better for jazz, acoustic, or singer-songwriter kits than heavy rock.

PHASE / TIMING — THE MAIN GOTCHA

Always time-align close mics to overheads.

2–4 ft of spacing between overheads = 2–3 ms of delay. That phasing on snare and toms will cancel more than it adds — you can literally make the snare quieter by raising overheads. Delay the close mics forward to match. Do this every show.

EQ STARTING POINTS

SM57 overheads

HPF 100–120 Hz. Cut 300–500 Hz if boxy. Shelf lift 8–12 kHz if too dark. Cut 3–5 kHz if cymbals are harsh. Less EQ than you'd think — the rolloff does useful work.

Audix i5 overheads

HPF 100 Hz. Similar to SM57 but aim carefully — hypercardioid means off-axis rejection is doing the work, so placement errors cost more than with a cardioid.

AEA R88 / ribbon overhead

HPF 80 Hz (gentle). Very little EQ needed — ribbons are naturally balanced. If the kit sounds dull, try a subtle high shelf at 10 kHz before reaching for anything else. Gain-hungry: watch preamp noise floor.

WHEN TO SKIP DYNAMICS AND RUN YOUR CONDENSERS

Classical or jazz with a natural room picture → **MKH 40s or Schoeps**. Acoustic/singer-songwriter where cymbal detail matters → **SM81s or Earthworks SR20sp**. Studio-style live recording → SDCs. Dynamics overhead make sense when you're fighting bleed, harshness, or feedback — not when you want transparency.